NCERT

HOW PAST GOVERNMENTS REVISED HISTORY

Governments of all persuasions have been guilty of trying to rewrite the history textbooks in the past

1960-1970



Education minister under three PMs including in **Jawaharlal Nehru**'s last term, M.C. Chagla, initiates the writing of new textbooks to give Indian history a 'secular', 'unbiased' and 'anti-colonial' view. He set up a committee which commissioned textbooks by eminent historians such as Romila Thapar, R.S. Sharma, Satish Chandra, Bipan Chandra and Arjun Dev. This exercise was monitored by Chagla's successor Saiyid Nurul Hasan from 1971. Critics claimed Hasan pushed writers who left a Marxist imprint on history texts.

In 1969, a parliamentary panel set up by the **Indira Gandhi** regime wanted the text on ancient India to state that the Aryans were indigenous to India. The demand was nixed by the editorial board as well as Thapar, who was the author.



Hindu and Sikh groups claimed their religions and religious leaders were ignored. The Hindu Mahasabha and Arya Samaj claimed the mention of beef-eating in ancient times hurt the sentiments of the "Hindu nationality".

1977



Following criticism that the Mughal era had been over-glorified, the **Morarji Desai**-led Janata Party government formed a panel of historians to examine textbooks in November 1977. Though the committee supported the continuance of the textbooks, the government withdrew R.S. Sharma's book on ancient India from the CBSE syllabus in July the following year.

asserts that one of the principal reasons why Marxist historians occupied prominent positions in India's best institutions of historical research in the 1980s was because they had access to state patronage.

Kannada novelist and philosopher S.L. Bhyrappa has, on multiple occasions, recounted how former prime minister Indira Gandhi mooted revising textbooks to bring "unity in the nation". She had formed a five-member committee headed by the diplomat-educationist G. Parthasarathy to monitor the revision. According to Bhyrappa, who was a member of the committee, Parthasarathy wanted the mention of Aurangzeb demolishing temples and constructing mosques at Kashi removed from textbooks. Bhyrappa, who earlier this year was awarded the Padma Bhushan, claims that because he did not agree with such conclusions, he was later removed from the committee.

> **"THERE HAS BEEN NO ATTEMPT TO CONSULT MEMBERS OF THE TEAMS THAT HAD PREPARED THE TEXTBOOKS"**
> *Statement by 250 historians in response to the changes in the school textbooks*

The writer also believes historians like R.S. Sharma and Satish Chandra wrongly attributed the decline of Buddhism to Emperor Ashoka banning the ritual of sacrificing birds and animals which put an end to the performance of yajnas. Brahmins thus lost their share of *dakshina* (cash gifts) and consequently their livelihood, which is why they revolted and the Maurya empire disintegrated after Ashoka's death. Bhyrappa instead turns to B.R. Ambedkar, a Buddhist himself, albeit not a professional historian, who wrote in his book *The Decline and Fall of Buddhism*: "The decline of Buddhism in India is due to the terrifying actions of Muslims." Ambedkar, he adds, noted how Muslim invaders destroyed the universities of Nalanda, Vikramasheela, Jagaddala, Odanthapura and brutally killed the Buddhist monks, causing "the worst catastro-